

Retirement is breaking the work habit and arranging your affairs to live off unearned income. As long as you *feel* retired and can live off unearned income, you're retired. I think you should settle in during a transition period and then concentrate on your to-do list for a minimum of two years. That way you'll develop a comfortable rhythm in your new life. But you can go back to work whenever you feel like it, full or part time, in two years or two decades.

MY FRIEND NICK

My second mentor, Nick, just turned 50. He was born in Albany, prepped at Groton, majored in history at Dartmouth, and spent two years in the army. During breaks he relaxed at the family estate in upstate, New York, or wandered through Latin America with Colombian friends from Groton.

Once his stint in the army was over he moved to Latin America for good. He tried Spain, Italy, and Yugoslavia before settling in the Costa del Sol. He now lives in a five-bedroom, view apartment in Marbella with his French wife, 16-year-old son, 10-year-old daughter, two maids, two dogs, three toucans, and anyone else who happens to be in town. That last category includes writers, artists, producers, actors, dancers, sculptors, museum curators, art dealers, and politicians. Anyone, it seems, except businessmen. Nick has few friends in business, perhaps because he's never been in business himself. To the outside observer, Nick's never worked at all.

"That's not true," he said when I asked him about it. "You just think I don't work because I don't spend much time working. But I buy things and sell things. I own a bookstore. At one time or other I've owned a restaurant, art gallery, hotel, and real estate company. It's just that I never run the businesses myself. I don't want them to interfere with my life."

Nick's a trader, a twentieth-century *marchand*. He buys in